to the archbishop of Gniezno, who had to instruct the relevant bishop, who had to send someone to intervene in the parish. That might take months, and there was ample opportunity for the archbishop, bishop and other intermediaries to reinterpret or even 'mislay' the pope's orders.[108]

Churches became more totalitarian institutions only in the late modern era, when modern information technologies became available. We tend to think of popes as medieval relics, but actually they are masters of modern technology. In the eighteenth century, the pope had little control over the worldwide Catholic Church and was reduced to the status of a local Italian princeling, fighting other Italian powers for control of Bologna or Ferrara. With the advent of radio, the pope became one of the most powerful people on the planet. Pope John Paul II could sit in the Vatican and speak directly to millions of Catholics from Poland to the Philippines, without any archbishop, bishop or parish priest able to twist or hide his words.[109]

HOW INFORMATION FLOWS

We see then that the new information technology of the late modern era gave rise to both large-scale democracy and large-scale totalitarianism. But there were crucial differences between how the two systems used information technology. As noted earlier, democracy encourages information to flow through many independent channels rather than only through the centre, and it allows many independent nodes to process the information and make decisions by themselves. Information freely circulates between private businesses, private media organisations, municipalities, sports associations, charities, families and individuals – without ever passing through the office of a government minister.

In contrast, totalitarianism wants *all* information to pass through the central hub and doesn't want any independent institutions making decisions on their own. True, totalitarianism does have its tripartite apparatus of government, party and secret police. But the whole point of this parallel apparatus is to prevent the emergence of any independent power that might challenge the centre. When government officials, party members and secret police agents constantly keep tabs on one another, opposing the centre is extremely dangerous.